Social Priming and Server Well-Being

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I. Introduction.

There is a strong intuition, if not strong empirical evidence, that preexisting concepts, relationships, and moral obligations play a substantive role in governing the interactions of players in virtual worlds. I will argue that, at least in the case of Minecraft servers specifically, conceptual and social cohesion in the real world prior to its instantiation in Minecraft is, on the whole, detrimental to the life of a server. This is likely due to the fact that such a cohesion presupposes shared utility functions among the constitutive members of a cohesive group, which, when augmented by the fact that Minecraft's gameplay loops allow the player to obtain an extreme abundance of resources beyond an initial curve, leads to the prioritization of the individual cohesive unit rather than the server as a whole.

II. Terminological Clarifications.

A. Priming

A *primed* player is a player with preexisting concepts, moral obligations, and rational norms that bear relevantly on their behavior in-game. To some extent, all players are primed, although some may be more relevantly primed than others. For example, *X* may be said to have, *pro tanto*, a greater degree of priming than *Y* given that *X* has had experience playing sandbox-type games before, while *Y* has had no such experience.

B. Social Priming

A *socially primed* player is a primed player whose set of conceptual elements includes preexisting real-world social relationships. However, these relations must have certain necessary and sufficient conditions; for it is not sufficient to stipulate that *any* preexisting social relationship is a sufficient condition for social priming. Let *S* be a set[1] of players *X*, *Y*, and *Z*. Insofar as all players in the set are necessarily:

> i) Acquainted with each other and/or share a certain degree of friendship (in the ordinary sense of the term),[2]
>
> ii) Cooperate with each other more often than not, *ceteris paribus*, and
>
> iii) Share similar goals, aims, and moral values more often than not, *ceteris paribus*,

[1] I will assume for simplicity's sake that a relevant set for us contains three or more players.
[2] By "ordinary" I simply mean the common-sense, non-technical sense of the word.

then *X*, *Y*, and *Z* can be said to be *socially primed* with respect to *S*. From hereon I will assume that any given socially primed player meets conditions (i)-(iii) and is primed with respect to a set of players.

C. Utility Functions

A *utility function*[3] is a function that takes states of affairs of the world as inputs and utility as its output. Utility is often conceived of in terms of *utils*. A *util* is an arbitrary unit used to posit the utility of a state of affairs or action. Consider two possible actions, A_1 and A_2, such that A_1 produces five utils and A_2 produces two utils. On standard utilitarian views, A_1 is the morally obligatory action to take, for it results in a greater amount of utility than A_2. Hence, the utility function of an agent, or in our case, a player, measures the utility generated by certain states of affairs relative to an individual. Therefore, it is possible for individual utility functions to differ across agents/players. Consider two agents, *P* and *Q*, with utility functions *u*(P) and *u*(Q), where *u(x)* can be said to be the general form of a utility function. Under *u*(P), the number of utils gained by eating ice cream may amount to ten; under *u*(Q), the number of utils gained by doing the same thing may only amount to one. Moreover, certain states of affairs or actions may not even figure into agents' utility functions at all. This will come into play later.

III. Server Goals and Player Properties

A. The Purpose of a Server

It is generally assumed, if not a widely held intuition, that the purpose of a server is to maximize the amount of enjoyment for the greatest number of players.[4] Though this broadly utilitarian characterization is by no means the only sort of characterization that could be made here, it will prove useful in setting a fixed point around which the parts of the server may revolve (players, moderation, gameplay, etc.). The gameplay loops of Minecraft, within the context of a server, are often used to coordinate the behavioral patterns of players around certain determinate goals or ends. These goals or ends, by extension, generally serve to increase the extent to which players may enjoy themselves on the server. Because these ends are only valuable insofar as players cooperate with others in order to satisfy those ends, we may be in a position to claim that players include interactions with other players squarely within the domain of their utility functions. Furthermore, those players would assign positive values to the relevant outputs of those functions. Let the cumulative utility of all shared events that involve player-to-player interaction be the *Server Utility* (SU).

The central claim here (C) is that:

(C) *All things being equal, i.e., under ideal conditions, servers with players who are socially primed, viz., with preexisting social, conceptual, and moral relationships with others in the*

[3] See [2]

[4] Note that this does not necessarily include moderators/staff, or administrators. On this view, if they benefit in any capacity, they only do so contingently (I doubt, from my experience, that they enjoy any part of it). This may obviously be argued against, but for our purposes here I will take the well-being of the players specifically as the primary object of study.

relevant ways, will always have a lower SU than servers with players who are not socially primed.

If this claim is true, social priming is, on the whole, undesirable for a server. If this claim is to be proven, we must explore the utility functions of socially primed players.

B. Priority

Recall the set *S* of players *X*, *Y*, and *Z*, where each player is socially primed with respect to *S*. Assume additionally that each player in the set has a utility function. Because of conditions (i)-(iii) for social priming, it would be quite difficult to argue that *X*, *Y*, and *Z* do *not* consider their fellow players within their utility functions; for if it were to be the case that *X* could either help *Y* or another random player, say *A*, *X* will in the majority of cases gain more utility by helping *Y* rather than *A*; furthermore, *Y* benefits from having *X* help them when needed. The dependence relation is thus *symmetrical*. Let us formulate the first derived claim (D_1), or the **PRIORITY**[5] premise thus:

(D_1) *For any group of players socially primed with respect to a set, the utility functions of each of the players within the set take* ***priority***[6] *over the utility functions of any other player, barring exceptional circumstances (e.g. when there are only strangers present on the server for a given time).*

The crucial thing to note here is that priming *entails* **PRIORITY**; as a player, it is in my best interests to prioritize my preexisting friends and social relationships over those that I hardly have any acquaintance with. Hence, I will prioritize the well-being of my friends over the well-being of the rest of the server.

This, however, is not enough to prove (C) on its own. It is a trivial observation that I tend to prioritize people I already know over people that I do not know (yet); but this does not entail, logically nor probabilistically, that this is harmful to the server overall. I can include both the general well-being of the server and the well-being of my compatriots within my utility function. This, however, need not always be the case in situations where social priming is involved.

C. First Steps to Exclusion

Though priority is one way in which a utility function can bear a relation to other utility functions, in that I prioritize certain agents' functions over others, there is a second way in which a utility function can have a relation (or lack thereof) to other functions, that being exclusion. Let us state the **first exclusion** premise (E) thus:

(E) *X excludes a utility function u(x) from their own, u(X), when none of the outputs of u(x) figure into the inputs of u(X).*

However, as of yet, we do not have a reason to think that socially primed players exclude the utility functions of other server members in any substantive way. At this point, though, we may

[5] This notion of priority is an heir of Rawls's notion of lexical priority, used primarily in ethics and political philosophy. See [1]

[6] I use priority in lowercase to indicate the concept, while I use PRIORITY in capital letters to indicate the claim itself. This also goes with further concepts and premises found later.

offer a probabilistic argument for why priority leads to exclusion. This argument is predicated on the properties of the feedback loops in Minecraft itself.

D. Scarcity and Exclusion

In the real world, resources are scarce; economic theory attempts to cope with this fact by determining the optimal course of action given the constraints on what we can choose. Minecraft, however, is devoid of scarcity altogether. The game has a theoretically infinite number of resources (if not a functionally unlimited amount); the only barrier is technological, or skill based. You cannot access certain resources given that you do not have the means to acquire them, such as farms, equipment, enchantments, etc.; but given that you do have those means, the number of resources available for you to collect is functionally indefinite.[7]

This means that any given player is entirely *self-sufficient*; if they so wish, they need not depend on other players in any capacity, for they are not bound by scarcity in the same way real-world agents are so bound. The crucial move here is to observe that this feature applies equally well to *groups* of players. If a group of players decides to become self-sufficient, as they cannot be said to be hampered by any sort of real scarcity, they certainly can do so with no effect on other players in the server in question. Hence, any calculations or rational assumptions regarding the management of resources, the well-being of the players within the group, or the overall experience of the group on the server need not factor in, to any extent, the utility functions of other players or groups of players. In this case, **first exclusion** (E) obtains. A subsidiary move here we must make is that *a set of socially primed players with* **prior** *utility functions is the most apt kind of group to exhibit* **first exclusion**; for, being primed already with preexisting utility functions, the probability of their becoming self-sufficient without any dependency whatsoever on other players is quite high. Therefore, let us consolidate these claims into our second derived claim (D_2), or the **exclusion** premise:

(D2) i) *X excludes a utility function u(x) from their own, u(X), when none of the outputs of u(x) figure into the inputs of u(X). ii) A set of socially primed players with* ***prior*** *utility functions is the most apt kind of group to exhibit (i) pertaining to the rest of the server.*

IV. The Full Argument.

It is evident that if (D_2) obtains, then a server with socially primed players will usually always have a lower SU than servers without socially primed players. For if (D_2) in fact obtains, the set of socially primed players with respect to that set excludes others' utility functions from their own evaluations, and hence server-wide events or other server-wide utility-maximizing forces are excluded from the evaluative purview of the socially primed set. Let us put together the overarching argument as follows, assuming ideal conditions, e.g. that there are other players, that these players are not socially primed, that all the utility functions work regularly, etc.:

Premise 1. There is a set of players S such that the players are socially primed with respect to S.

[7] This, of course, excludes edge cases in which there are indeed scarce resources, e.g. dragon eggs; but the point here is that most resources in the game that matter are functionally infinite, and available to anyone with the requisite means and determination.

Premise 2. (**PRIORITY**) If there is a group of players socially primed with respect to a set, then the utility functions of each of the players within the set take **priority** over the utility functions of any other player, barring exceptional circumstances.

Intermediate Conclusion 1. Each of the utility functions of the players in S take priority.

Premise 3. (**exclusion**) i) *X excludes* a utility function *u(x)* from their own, *u*(X), when *none* of the outputs of *u(x)* figure into the inputs of *u*(X).

ii) A set of socially primed players with prior utility functions is the most apt kind of group to exhibit (i) pertaining to the rest of the server.

Intermediate Conclusion 2. S is of the sort that is most likely to exhibit **exclusion**.

Intermediate Conclusion 3. So, S exhibits **exclusion** by probability.

Premise 4. If a server has a set of players that exhibits **exclusion**, the SU of that server will on the whole be lower than a server without such a set.

Conclusion. (C) All things being equal, i.e., under ideal conditions, servers with players who are socially primed, viz., with preexisting social, conceptual, and moral relationships with others in the relevant ways, will always have a lower SU than servers with players who are not socially primed.

V. Potential Solutions and Conclusion.

This conclusion accords well with observation; often, preexisting cliques and groups are scarcely willing to participate in the activities of a server as a whole and prefer to keep to themselves and their own sphere of action. This is often to the detriment of the server, as such behavior limits player-to-player interaction, dulls the social life of the server, and renders the server down to a platform on which individual groups can play on a server without fear of having to interact with anyone else.

All the while, this sort of behavior occurs under perfectly rational (in a sense) conditions; it is through no fault of the socially primed player's own that they prefer to help or cooperate with those whom they trust rather than random people on the server. This is simply how we value others' actions relative to those we interact with more often. This does not touch, however, on the moral obligations people have towards others on a server, which may well entail that they interact with strangers for the sake of the well-being of all and the server at large, a position that I myself find quite plausible. There is also the problem of *intra-server* cohesion, which makes manifest the possibility that priority and exclusion obtain even in groups formed *within* the server rather than socially-primed players. If this so happens to be the case, which it certainly is given that people often form friendships and social groups on the server itself, what is their ontological and ethical status? Should the server administration curtail their formation, or deal with their consequences as they go along? What to do about this phenomenon, though, is not within the scope of this article.

The most obvious solution, assuming that socially primed players will always be present to some extent, is to integrate more elegantly the incentives of the server with the incentives that the socially primed player feels compelled to act on with respect to the set in which they are

primed. A server may restrict resources and create a sense of scarcity in order that groups are forced to cooperate and interact. A server may also enforce proximity requirements, requiring all players to stay within a certain area so as to promote cooperation and shared ends. Another potential route is the elimination of socially primed players altogether; if everyone were to lack social priming, there may be more of an incentive on the part of each individual player to foment social interactions for their continued enjoyment. I, personally, have no opinions on the matter, apart from generally accepting the conclusion that unregulated social priming is, overall, detrimental; I leave it up as an exercise to the reader to determine what sort of solution in this situation, given the foregoing assumptions, maximizes the well-being of a server.

References

[1] Rawls, J. (1999). *A Theory of Justice: Revised Edition*. Harvard University Press.

[2] Steele, Katie, and H. Orri Stefánsson, *Decision Theory*, The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (Fall 2025 Edition), Edward N. Zalta & Uri Nodelman (eds.)